

MITRE ATT&CK Threat Analysis

Lazarus Group — Top 5 Techniques

Source: MITRE ATT&CK Enterprise Matrix | Group: G0032 | By: Jessica Sansaricq

Overview

Lazarus Group (also tracked as HIDDEN COBRA and ZINC) is a North Korean state-sponsored threat actor active since at least 2009. The group is responsible for a wide range of operations including financial theft, espionage, and destructive attacks. The five techniques below represent the most consistently observed behaviors across Lazarus Group campaigns, drawn from MITRE ATT&CK threat intelligence data.

Key Techniques

1. Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment (T1566.001)

Technique ID	T1566.001
Name	Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment
Tactic	Initial Access
Description	Lazarus Group sends targeted emails with malicious Microsoft Word or DOTM file attachments to specific individuals. When the victim opens the document, hidden VBA macros or embedded shellcode silently execute malware on their system — giving the attackers their first foothold.
Real-World Example	<i>During Operation Dream Job, victims received emails disguised as job offers from defense and aerospace companies. Opening the attachment triggered malicious macros that downloaded further payloads.</i>

2. Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell (T1059.001)

Technique ID	T1059.001
Name	Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell
Tactic	Execution
Description	After gaining initial access, Lazarus Group uses PowerShell — a built-in Windows scripting tool — to run commands, explore the victim's environment, and execute additional malicious code. Because PowerShell is a legitimate system tool, its activity is harder for security software to flag as suspicious.
Real-World Example	<i>During Operation Dream Job, the group ran PowerShell commands to map out the compromised environment, enumerate users, and pull down additional malware stages from attacker-controlled servers.</i>

3. Develop Capabilities: Malware (T1587.001)

Technique ID	T1587.001
Name	Develop Capabilities: Malware
Tactic	Resource Development
Description	Rather than using off-the-shelf hacking tools, Lazarus Group develops its own custom malware tailored for each campaign. Custom tools like Torisma, DRATzarus, ThreatNeedle, and BLINDINGCAN are built from scratch, meaning standard antivirus signatures are far less likely to catch them on initial deployment.
Real-World Example	<i>For Operation Dream Job, Lazarus developed Sumarta, DBLL Dropper, Torisma, and DRATzarus — each serving a distinct purpose in their multi-stage attack chain, from initial access to long-term surveillance.</i>

4. Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols (T1071.001)

Technique ID	T1071.001
Name	Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols
Tactic	Command and Control
Description	Lazarus Group communicates with infected machines using standard HTTP and HTTPS web traffic — the same protocols used by everyday web browsing. By blending their command-and-control (C2) communications into normal-looking traffic, they make it very difficult for network monitoring tools to identify or block their activity.
Real-World Example	<i>The group has used both HTTP and HTTPS to contact attacker-controlled C2 servers during Operation Dream Job, sometimes leveraging compromised legitimate websites as relay points to further obscure the traffic source.</i>

5. Archive Collected Data: Archive via Utility (T1560.001)

Technique ID	T1560.001
Name	Archive Collected Data: Archive via Utility
Tactic	Collection
Description	Before exfiltrating stolen data, Lazarus Group compresses victim files into RAR or ZIP archives — often with encryption applied. This serves two purposes: it reduces the size of data for faster transfer, and it makes the contents unreadable to network security tools inspecting outbound traffic.
Real-World Example	<i>During Operation Dream Job, the group archived victim data into RAR files before exfiltrating it to Dropbox using a customized version of the open-source dbxcli command-line tool.</i>

Quick Reference Summary

ID	Technique Name	Tactic	Key Behavior
T1566.001	Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment	Initial Access	Lazarus Group sends targeted emails with malicious Microsoft Word or DOTM file attachments to specific individuals.
T1059.001	Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell	Execution	After gaining initial access, Lazarus Group uses PowerShell — a built-in Windows scripting tool — to run commands, explore the victim's environment, and execute additional malicious code.
T1587.001	Develop Capabilities: Malware	Resource Development	Rather than using off-the-shelf hacking tools, Lazarus Group develops its own custom malware tailored for each campaign.
T1071.001	Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols	Command and Control	Lazarus Group communicates with infected machines using standard HTTP and HTTPS web traffic — the same protocols used by everyday web browsing.
T1560.001	Archive Collected Data: Archive via Utility	Collection	Before exfiltrating stolen data, Lazarus Group compresses victim files into RAR or ZIP archives — often with encryption applied.